Cooked cucumber has a subtle flavor which combines particularly well with the more assertive but still delicate tarragon in this light soup.

hot cucumber and tarragon soup

SERVES 4 **PREP** 15 MINS **COOK** 20 MINS **FREEZE** NOT SUITABLE

2 medium-large or 3 small cucumbers
1 tbsp sunflower oil
3 tbsp chilled butter, diced
2 tbsp chopped fresh tarragon
3⅓ cups light vegetable or chicken stock
salt and freshly ground black pepper
2 tbsp cornstarch
4 heaped tsp cream cheese (optional)

1 Peel the cucumbers, cut crosswise in half, then cut each half lengthwise. With a pointed teaspoon, scoop out and discard all the seeds and chop the flesh coarsely.

2 Place a sauté pan over medium heat. Add the oil and 1 tbsp of the butter. Once the butter has melted, add the cucumber and half the tarragon. Stir for 2 minutes, then pour in the stock and season lightly with salt and pepper.

3 Bring to a simmer, reduce the heat a little, then cover and simmer gently for 10–15 minutes. Stir in the cornstarch. Cook for 2 minutes. Take off the heat and set aside to cool a little.

4 Transfer to a blender or food processor and blend until smooth. Return to the pan and whisk in the remaining butter. Taste and adjust the seasoning, stir in the rest of the tarragon, and serve hot. If you like, add a dollop of cream cheese (if using) to each serving at the last minute.